

WILL AND WILEY'S LAST FLIGHT.
(FIRST DRAFT)

There were few boys growing up in Oklahoma ^{that} had no heroes in the 1930's. The man that always caught my attention and for whom I had the highest admiration was Will Rogers. Running a close second to Will was a well known airplane pilot with only one good eye. He was easily recognized wherever he went as he always wore a white eye patch over his left eye. He was Wiley Post. The fact that both of them met their deaths together was a tremendous shock to me.

They say that whenever a great tragedy strikes that affects you deeply, you will always be able to remember exactly where you were and what you were doing at the time. This is true.

On August 15, 1935 I was in the back yard of our house on Elm Street working on our club house which we had been building. I was up on the roof nailing down strips of tarpaper when my mom came to the back door. She had been in the kitchen fixing us some lunch. She pushed the screen door open and held it so it wouldn't bang shut. She had a funny look on her face. She said to me, "Jimmy, come here. I have something to tell you." I climbed down from the roof and as I got closer to mom I could see she was crying.

"What's wrong, mom?" I asked her.

"They just said on the radio that Will Rogers and Wiley Post's plane had crashed up in Alaska."

"Are they alright?" I asked hopefully.

"They're both dead, son"

It was my turn to cry now. It didn't seem possible. Things like that just aren't supposed to happen to heroes.... especially someone like Will Rogers. Why, he was one of the best known and best loved men in the entire world at that time.

And ole Wiley, ~~Wiley~~ sure he only had one good eye, but he was one heckova' flyer. He had been a barnstormer as a new young pilot. He only had one good eye even then. In fact, he had bought his first airplane with the insurance money he had gotten for the loss of his eye. But he was born to fly, a natural pilot. He took people up for rides to earn his first money in aviation. Because of his reputation as an excellent pilot he was hired to fly the plane that was owned by two Oklahoma oil men. Wiley later worked as a test pilot for Lockheed. Then in 1933 he made the first solo flight around the world in a plane called the "Winnie Mae". During these years Will Rogers and Wiley Post got to know one another and became good friends. Each one held the other in extremely high regard. Of course, the fact that they were both Oklahomans only helped to seal their bond even more secure.

I wondered what the heck Mr. Rogers wanted to be flying up to Alaska for in the first place. 'Course I knew he traveled a lot. He was always going to some foreign country or going to different parts of the United States. He would always make a speech, just about wherever he went. And people always listened to what he had to say. He had become world famous having made several movies and also writing a newspaper column.

Mom and I sat down on the porch together. She put one arm around my shoulder and with her other hand she wiped at her eyes with the apron she was wearing. This was my first experience at losing someone I loved, to death. I didn't like the feeling. I couldn't begin to understand why it had to happen.

My first recollection of Will Rogers was when I was about six years old. He was already famous by then and he had moved out to California and bought himself a ranch. Herbert Hoover had been elected President of the United States in 1928, and this was the first time I became aware of politics and government. Will Rogers had run for president in that election. He had been nominated, as a joke really, by the old Life magazine. I didn't understand that he was not a real candidate and when we heard on our radio that Mr. Hoover had been elected I was mad. I had wanted Will Rogers to be president because he was from Oklahoma.

Will's favorite target for his humor was politicians. He delighted in being able to poke fun at them.

The first movie I remember seeing Will in was "A Connecticut Yankee". It was about some man who got hit on the head and woke up back in the days of King Arthur in England. He made others, all of which I saw. David Harum, State Fair, and one of my favorites, Steamboat 'Round The Bend. Will always had interesting characters with him in every movie. The two I remember best were a tall, skinny

black man named Stepin Fetchit. He would stand there, looking at you with those big sleepy eyes and talk in a mumble which was almost impossible to decipher, but it always made an audience roar with laughter. The other character was a man named Slim Summerille. Slim always played some dumb hick part. He was tall, stoop shouldered, and had a two or three day growth of beard. He wore wire rim glasses which were always down on the end of his nose. He didn't have to say a word to get a laugh. He'd just give you a look across the top rim of his glasses that said "Nobody loves me." You always felt so sorry for him, that your laughter came as a sympathetic reaction to such a poor, pitiful man.

Will's weekly newspaper columns were always full of humor. He poked fun at many great men. He once said, "It's alright to make fun of a man as long as he's a great man, but you better be sure he is really great."

On congressmen, he wrote this,

"You know Congressmen are the nicest fellows in the world to meet. I sometimes really wonder if they realize the harm they do."

Will Rogers was a much needed panacea during the 1930's when our country was in the depression. He kept us all laughing and he went around raising money to help people who desperately needed help. Most of his money raising was done in Oklahoma, Arkansas, and Texas, areas for which he had a particular feeling. His concern for those stricken in poverty was genuine and it had results. He became one of the best loved figures in the public eye.

The plane flight which ended in their death hadn't been planned far in advance. Wiley Post had long wanted to fly ~~unmanned~~ from Alaska across to Russian Siberia, mainly just to prove that an air route up in that part of the world made sense.

Will Rogers had always wanted to see Alaska. He admired the great pioneer spirit of the Americans who lived there. He just wanted to go up and see what it was like. To him, it was going to be a fun trip with an old friend and fellow Oklahoman.

Their plane went down in an icy lagoon ^{near} ~~the~~ Point Barrow, Alaska. They crashed in the mid-afternoon of August 15, 1935. The newspapers wrote that Wiley Post's watch had stopped at 8:18 p.m. He was on Oklahoma time. It was the following day before the crash became general knowledge and was broadcast on the radio. ~~news stations~~

They flew Wiley Post's body back to Oklahoma City. Will Rogers was flown back to Burbank, California and he was buried in Forest Lawn Cemetery. The entire country and many parts of the world were in mourning. In Claremore, Oklahoma which was to eventually become Will's final resting place, a memorial service was held.

In 1938, the Will Rogers Memorial was built in Claremore. It was a beautiful site, located on a hillside, and on it was built a building of native Oklahoma stone which would house all the memorabilia of this great, humble man. I went there in 1940, my year as a senior in high school. It was a grand experience to see things that had belonged to Will Rogers.

His typewriter, his saddles some plain, some heavy with silver ornamentation. Letters he had received from Presidents and kings.

Standing in the center of a large high ceilinged hall stood a bronze statue of Will Rogers. He's looking right at you with that mischievous grin, hair hanging down on his forehead. Carved on the granite base is one of the finest things Will ever said,
"I never met a man I didn't like."